political sledgehammer for the BJP's publicity machinery. It has dominated and shaped the political discourse as well as the party's public image.

It is surprising then to look at the BJP's official public communications in their entirety and discover that the discourse around development, farmers and infrastructure was far higher than that on its core issues (see Figures 6.1, 6.7). The party's core issues are central to its political positioning, but they form part of a wider, cohesive pattern of strategic communications.

Of course, after the Pulwama terrorist attack and the Balakot air strikes by the Indian Air Force in early 2019, the BJP's mentions of terrorism rose by 400 per cent in 2019 (see Table 6.1). Yet, interestingly, this was still far lower than how intensely the party focused on it a decade earlier, in 2006–2008 (see Figure 6.8). That it spoke much more about terrorism in 2008 is understandable, since that was the year of the Mumbai terror attacks. But, even in 2006 and 2007, the focus on terrorism was high, with the BJP accusing the UPA government of being weak on terror.

Figure 6.8: The BJP's Communications on Core Ideological Issues (Terrorism, Defence, Kashmir, Hinduism, Temple) Changed Strategically Over Time: Mentions in Press Releases, Articles Speeches (2005–2019)